

No. 13

**Letter by the Chairman of the SPD, Brandt, to the General Secretary
of the CC of the CPSU, Brezhnev**

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English translation: Dwight E. Langston

Dear Mr. General Secretary,

First of all I would like to thank you for your letter of 22 February 1982,² in which you express your thoughts and concerns about the status of negotiations in Geneva.³ You can rest assured that we are following these negotiations with the utmost interest.

Without a doubt, the present status is unsatisfactory. I also do not consider it a good thing that a two-month Easter recess⁴ might leave the impression that those conducting the negotiations are not in any hurry at all.

I do not sit at the negotiating table, and therefore form my opinion based on what I hear from the participants. All the same, I certainly do not need to emphasise how important your impressions are in this matter. For that reason, I would consider it helpful if our previously tried and tested channels of communication remained available.

Allow me to say this with my usual forthrightness: For me, the American Zero Option⁵ seems to be a starting point for the negotiations, but a point at which, as everyone knows, things cannot remain frozen. By the same token, the Soviet Union's proposals, as they have been presented so far, are also not acceptable.

There is no doubt that the Soviet proposal for a Zero Option⁶ is not achievable today; it is, as I hear, not under serious consideration at all

in Geneva. They are concentrating on the phased plan which I, from the viewpoint of Germany's interests, do not consider a good idea.⁷

In any event, 600 systems on both sides would mean, for example, that American missiles would have to be stationed here. The Americans are free to replace outmoded aircraft systems with new missile systems. It must be astonishing to many that the Soviet Union itself is proposing this, because by doing so, in principle, it opens up the possibility of creating with its consent a situation which it usually characterises as a fundamental change to its disadvantage in the strategic situation. You know that I have never belonged to those who are anxious when the two superpowers reach an agreement, because an agreement by the two most powerful nations means détente. Any agreement is better than none. Nevertheless, as far as missiles are concerned, I still consider it desirable that this not happen at our expense. You will certainly understand that.

My impression is that negotiations are in their initial stage. I think it conceivable that they will enter a serious phase only when precise American ideas on reducing inter-continental missiles and on negotiations in Vienna⁸ become known, which we should be able to expect from a speech by the American president this May.⁹

The position on this issue which you, Mr. General Secretary, took in your address to the Congress of Trade Unions¹⁰ is a helpful one to me even if we cannot gauge whether or not the Soviet Union has already achieved its production goals with the SS 20s. In any event, your unilateral decision can signify a stabilisation of the situation and thereby facilitate negotiations as long as the Americans are not technically capable of stationing their missiles, which, as you know, would require six years, therefore not until 1989. Thus, the issue of an agreed-on moratorium¹¹ in the autumn of 1983 will be most significant if negotiations have not resulted in an agreement by that time.

We have a crucial year ahead of us which will require strength and steady nerves, from you as well as from us, so that developments

remain calculable and can be turned in a good direction. I hope that the trust which has grown between us can help achieve that.

Yours truly,

<Willy Brandt>¹²

¹ The template copy is a copy of Brandt's letter. Typewritten note at the end of the document: "Delivery via/E[gon] B[ahr], copy: H[ans-]J[ürgen] W[ischnewski]".

² No. 74.

³ Meant here are the US-Soviet negotiations in Geneva on limitation of intermediate range nuclear forces (INF).

⁴ On 16 March 1982 the negotiations were postponed to 20 May 1982. Cf. EA 37 (1982) 8, l. 84.

⁵ Cf. No. 73, Note 19.

⁶ On 24 February 1982 Brezhnev presented a range of proposals for disarmament, including an agreement to end the production of nuclear weapons and to reduce and later completely destroy all existing arsenals. Cf. EA 37 (1982) 6, l. 58.

⁷ Brandt favored the realization of a "Zero Option", which should supersede completely the deployment of new American medium-range ballistic missiles in Western Europe. Cf. for the state of INF-negotiations in Geneva: EA 37 (1982) 4, l. 42.

⁸ On 28 January 1982 the 26th round of, by then unsuccessful, MBFR negotiations started in Vienna. The Polish crisis further paralysed the talks. On 18 February 1982 the Polish delegates presented a draft agreement; the West assured to study it carefully. No agreement could be reached in the so-called data question.

⁹ Brandt refers to the speech of President Reagan from 9 May 1982 in Illinois, where he had submitted the American proposals for disarmament of strategic weapons (START) and set the start of negotiations to the end of July 1982. Cf. EA 37 (1982) 11, l. 116.

¹⁰ Brandt refers to Brezhnev's opening speech to the XVII. Congress of Soviet Trade Unions on 16 March 1982 in Moscow and his explanation that Soviet leadership had decided a unilateral moratorium for the deployment of medium-range nuclear weapons in the European part of the Soviet Union. Cf. AdG 52 (1982), p. 25419 f.

¹¹ Cf. No. 65, Note 15.

¹² Handwritten signature.